

African empires

The continent of Africa was filled with many flourishing kingdoms and empires between the 5th and 15th centuries. It was rich in natural resources, so the cities of these empires bustled with trade. From the 7th century, the new religion of Islam began to spread across Africa, influencing the culture of many of these empires.

Despite Africa's huge size and varied lands and cultures, its civilizations were connected by important trade networks. Several kingdoms grew around the coastal areas or large rivers that served these trade routes, and became wealthy. Camels were used to transport goods such as gold across the Sahara Desert from sub-Saharan Africa to North Africa, where they were traded. In West Africa, the empires of Ghana and Mali grew incredibly rich, trading gold and ivory for salt and copper

mined in the Sahara. In southeast Africa, Great Zimbabwe was known for its gold, copper, and ivory.

The Islamic empire spread from the Middle East into North Africa during the 7th century and Muslim kings gradually came to rule in several of Africa's powerful empires and kingdoms. Islam had a big impact on African culture and architecture. Construction began on many palaces and mosques, and Muslim scholars founded places of learning, such as schools, libraries, and universities.



▲ MAJOR AFRICAN EMPIRES

There were hundreds of different African cultures during this period, but some of the largest were the empires of Ghana and Mali in West Africa, Great Zimbabwe in the southeast, and the Zagwe Kingdom and Kilwa Sultanate on the eastern coast.

▼ KILWA SULTANATE

The Kilwa Sultanate was centered on Kilwa, an island off the coast of modern-day Tanzania. At its height between the 12th and 15th centuries, the Sultanate traded as far as China, India, and Sri Lanka. The gold trade and its strategic position made Kilwa the most powerful place on the Swahili coast.



KILWA COINS